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# Measuring public value: a conceptual and applied contribution to the debate

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*Countries facing austerity measures need to create public value. Academics and practitioners have been discussing the ways in which public value can be created, managed and measured. This paper contributes to this conversation by proposing a public value measurement model. An Italian case study is presented to demonstrate the feasibility of the model and the organizational implications when public value measures are available to public sector managers, politicians and the public.*

**Keywords: Cultural services; municipalities; performance measurement; public value; value pyramid.**

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## Introduction

With many countries recovering slowly from the economic crisis, increasing pressure is being put on public administrations to do more with less. The creation of public value is critical to counteract austerity policies in place. The academic literature offers a number of definitions of public value and explanations of the need for public value creation, but there are few contributions on how public value can be measured and made 'visible' and manageable.

This paper focuses on how to measure the value created by a public administration (Spano, 2009; Marcon, 2014; Moore, 2014). First, we present a model, informed by the relevant literature about what public value is and how it can be created, which can be used to measure public value generated by a public administration. Second, we test our model with a case study to highlight its strengths and weaknesses, together with its usefulness for practitioners.

Our case study was the Italian municipality of Ferrara, in particular its cultural and tourist services and events in 2013 and 2014. Ferrara is a medium-sized city in the north east of Italy, its historical centre is a Unesco World Cultural Heritage site and it is extremely popular with tourists. The city council has been investing in cultural events to attract more tourism in order to offset a decline in chemical and engineering industries on which the local economy used to rely.

The paper broadens the work of previous researchers (Poddighe and Deidda Gagliardo, 2011; Bracci *et al*., 2014) by providing a refined model for public value measurement, and applying it to a city's cultural and tourist services.

## Understanding public value

The most important early use of the term 'public value' was by Moore (1995) who conceived a strategic triangle based on a strategy which had to (1) create something valuable; (2) obtain legitimacy and political sustainability from the authorizing environment; and (3) be operationally feasible (Moore, 1995, p. 71). A new field of study, public value management, emerged and was considered by some as a new paradigm to rethink government activities, service delivery systems and public policies (O'Flynn, 2007). The public value management literature includes many works that are trying to conceptualize what public value is, find possible avenues for its creation and to measure it. This situation was summarized by Horner and Hutton's (2011) as the 'public value dynamic', which was made up of three conceptual areas:

- Authorize.
- Create.
- Measure.

The multifaceted concept of public value implies a broad spectrum of possible interpretations in the literature. According to Kelly *et al*. (2002, p. 4), 'public value refers to the value created by government through

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services, laws, regulation and other actions'. Alford considers that citizens are the judges of what public value is through direct contact with policy-makers and politicians as well as through the ballot box (Alford, 2002a, pp. 338–339). Smith states that public value changes over time and is continually redefined through socio-political interactions (Smith, 2004, p. 68). This point of view is confirmed by Stoker, who states that: 'the judgment of what is public value is collectively built through deliberation involving elected and appointed government officials and key stakeholders' (Stoker, 2006, p. 42). In O'Flynn's view, 'public value has been described as a multi-dimensional construct—a reflection of collectively expressed, politically mediated preferences consumed by the citizenry—created not just through outcomes but also through processes which may generate trust or fairness' (O'Flynn, 2007, p. 358).

The importance of public value is such that Benington and Moore (2011) contend that the public administration has a duty to stimulate debate about public value within society to know what everyone considers valuable in the public sphere. Talbot states that the concept of public value is contemporaneously formed by public interest, self-interest and procedural interest (Talbot, 2011, p. 30). These components must be considered in a conceptual framework that 'provides a guide to public managers or whoever is seeking to create public value' (Talbot, 2011, p. 31). The literature has underlined the importance of value as a fundamental component of public administration, grounded in the ability to satisfy citizens' needs and to promote mutual trust and fairness. However, a long-term view should be adopted, as the public administration should be able to generate value for future generations. Considering the case of local government, Deidda Gagliardo (2002, p. 185) notes that public value is 'the global widened and integrated value of a local administration, that expresses the capacity to satisfy the community's actual and future needs'. There is no value if the satisfaction of today's needs is pursued at the expense of the ability to achieve the same (or more) in the future.

According to Moore (1995, p. 211), there are five levels in public value creation: namely quantity and quality increase in public activities; cost reductions; better understanding of citizens' needs and then satisfying those needs; increased fairness in the public sector; better skills. Two perspectives arise from this in terms of value creation:

- The citizen's perspective—wanting his/her needs satisfied.
- The public administration's perspective—using resources efficiently so as not to endanger its ability to deliver public value in the future.

However, the creation of public value involves both the provision of benefits (for instance an increase in the quantity of services offered) and the imposition of sacrifices (such as higher taxation). Value is created if there is a high level of benefits and a low level of sacrifices (Spano, 2009). However, there is a complex relationship between benefits and sacrifices (Deidda Gagliardo, 2002)—higher taxation increases the sacrifices imposed on citizens, but it will also benefit the public administration (more resources available). As a result, benefits and sacrifices should be evaluated in the light of political programmes, prioritizing actions which politicians consider are critical to the generation of value (Spano, 2009).

A critical element in the creation of public value, most especially in times of decreasing resources, is the partnership between public, private, not-for-profit organizations and citizens. This issue has been extensively analysed in the public governance literature, which focuses on the need to promote co-operation, fairness and democracy in public service delivery as opposed to the quasi-market system promoted by New Public Management (Osborne, 2006). Interactions between network actors, who exchange resources in a trust-rooted negotiated rule system (Rhodes, 1997), are functional to public value creation. In particular, increasing attention is being paid to the involvement of citizens in value co-creation, with Pestoff and Brandsen (2010) identifying four levels of democracy in public service delivery: representative democracy; participative democracy; consumerism; and the co-production of services. Osborne and Strokosch (2013) go further with the identification of the different co-production types, by affirming that they could promote both user value and user participation. In addition, in some cases they may lead to experimental ways of service co-production. Bovaird and Löffler (2012) consider co-production as an activity oriented to good purpose through an interrelation between practitioners and the public. Alford (2002b) identifies five different motivators for citizen co-creation: sanctions; material rewards; intrinsic rewards; solidary incentives; and expressive values.

The final and most problematic area of public value is measurement (Moore, 2014). In order to make value 'visible', the tools and methodologies identified in the public performance management and measurement literature are useful (Deidda Gagliardo, 2015).

Two main approaches are apparent, with the first based on the use of balanced scorecards. According to Kloot and Martin (2000), the measurement process is based on primary and secondary objectives. The former is the desired result; the latter is its determinant. Secondary objectives are considered functional to achieving the primary ones. Kloot and Martin developed a balanced measurement approach based on existing models. They used the original dimension in the balanced scorecard to measure secondary goals (internal business process and innovation and learning dimensions), and primary goals (financial and customers' dimensions) (Kloot and Martin, 2000, p. 235). The scorecard approach was also used by Moore in his public value scorecard model, where the original dimensions of Kaplan and Norton's scorecard were replaced by the three components of a strategic triangle (Moore, 2003). Talbot, starting from Moore's model, and adding two dimensions underlined by Kelly *et al*. (2002), describes his public value creation framework as having five different components: social results focus; trust and legitimacy focus; services focus; resources focus; and processes focus (Talbot, 2011, p. 32).

The second approach is the use of multidimensional models which are not based on a scorecard approach. Marcon (2014) describes some models that have been used in practice, such as the BBC model, contributions from Work Foundation, the public ROI framework, and Accenture's public service value governance framework. However, these models do not identify a single synthetic public value measure. The public service value methodology devised by Cole and Parston (2006) is a notable exception that tries to score different outcomes, which are then normalized through a common scale. These scores are put together with their related cost-effectiveness scores, using a method that ranks the outcomes obtained with a given amount of public resources. In any case, this contribution considers public value creation as a single episode and not in an intergenerational perspective, with a focus on external effects without considering the internal dimensions of public administration.

**Towards a public value measurement model**

In this paper, public value is conceived of as the public administration's ability to achieve and maintain an equilibrium between the satisfaction of a community's needs (for example a decrease in unemployment) and the public administration's needs (i.e. balanced revenues and expenditures), as mediated by political priorities. As a result, any public value measurement system should focus on the key benefits and sacrifices involved in the process of value creation (Moore, 2014); promoting the needs of the community and safeguarding the long-term interests of the public administration (Spano, 2009). It should consider both the citizens' and the public administration's perspective, capturing its key dimensions through multidimensional indicators, with a weighting that reflects political priorities (Bracci *et al.,* 2014). From the public administration's perspective, this means focusing not only on financial sustainability, but also on the key intangible non-mission based aspects (Bryson and Crosby, 2014) which fuel value creation. The measurement model should provide citizens and practitioners with a single measure, to make public value easily visible and comparable over time and space. This model can be understood in terms of the value pyramid in figure 1.

As explained earlier, public value is generated when social, economic and intangible benefits are higher than related sacrifices. Social value (SV) is the citizens' satisfaction with public services in qualitative, quantitative, temporal and monetary terms, and is generated by maximizing the differential between social benefits (SB) and social sacrifices (SS). Economic value (EV), from the public administration's perspective, is its economic performance, financial stability and efficiency. EV is created when economic benefits (EB) are greater than economic sacrifices (ES).

Intangible value (IV), from the public administration's perspective, is created when intangible benefits (IB) are greater than intangible sacrifices (IS). This dimension is critical as it focuses on the main constituents of the public administration, such as its organization, its human resources, its links with other public, private or non-for-profit bodies and its ability to understand the changes in the context in which it operates and to evolve accordingly. Five types of IV are considered: structural; human; relational; empathetic; and evolutionary.

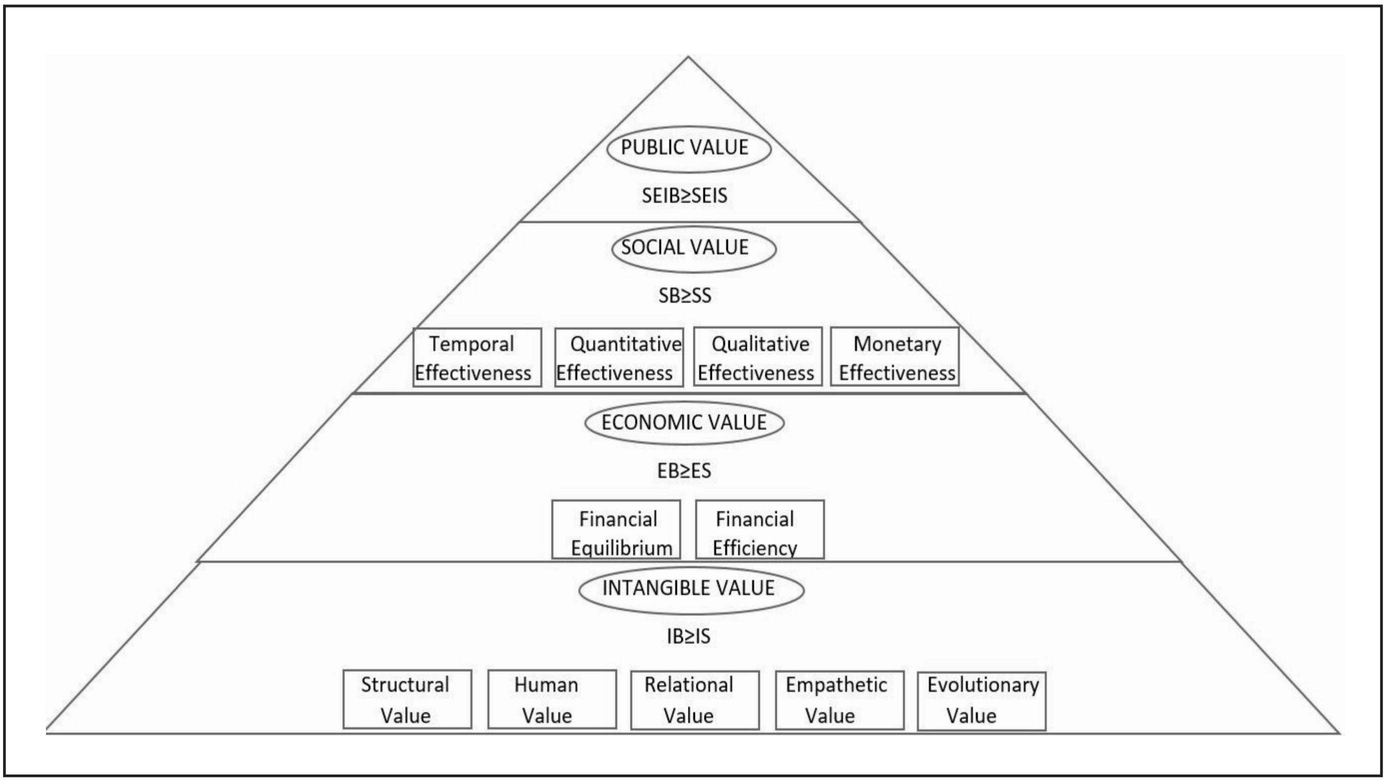
To meaningfully compare benefits and sacrifices, the model uses a measurement grid (see figure 2, where the column letters show the model's steps), where the results of the above dimensions determine the synthetic measure of the public value created (Column O). Each dimension (Column A) is divided into subdimensions (Column B), which reflect particular aspects of public value and their relevant value drivers (Column D). Every subdimension is dual: the value drivers for measuring both sacrifices and benefits are defined for each of them (Columns C and D). Then, for every value driver, an indicator has to be chosen (Column E). The value drivers could be determined both through a mono-polar correlation, where benefits and sacrifices are conceptually linked but expressed in two antithetical scales, and through a multi-polar correlation, where benefits and sacrifices are mathematically or statistically linked and expressed in a single scale (when an increase in benefits implies an automatic decrease in sacrifices and vice versa).

The measurement grid uses the mathematical tool of normalization to translate the results obtained through heterogeneous quantitative and qualitative indicators (Column I) into a common relative scale, which is decimal-based in our model (Column J). The normalization process (Arboretti Giancristofaro *et al.*, 2009) is fundamental when dealing with a public administration's performance because of the need to compare input, output and outcome measures, which can be expressed in quantitative, qualitative or monetary terms. The normalization tool, which traces these heterogeneous metrics back to a common scale, enables a public administration to make homogeneous comparisons between benefits and sacrifices (Deidda Gagliardo, 2015). The normalized measures for benefits range from 0 (the worst benefit obtainable for the value driver) to 10. Sacrifices rated 10 are the highest obtainable (worst result), while sacrifices equal to 0 are the lowest (best result). Every subdimension was weighted as a percentage within its dimension (Column K) and each dimension was weighted as a percentage of total value created or consumed (Column M). Public value was measured both synthetically, through a single measure which represents the total value created, and analytically, through measures for every dimension and subdimension.

**Methodological issues**

The public value measurement model presented in the previous section was tested in Ferrara. The municipality of Ferrara gave us full access to their relevant data and provided

**Figure 1. The value pyramid.**



support during the implementation of the model. In order to fully appreciate the benefits and limits of the model, we focused on a single policy area—the implementation of the cultural and tourist services, which ranged from street music festivals to exhibitions of world-famous artists' work; Ferrara also hosts the oldest 'Palio' (horse race) in the world (Accorsi and Rimondi, 2008). The municipality was keen to understand what citizens and tourists most valued (concept); it organized events in collaboration with non-profit organizations, associations and volunteers (creation and co-creation); and was willing to measure the public value that was created or consumed (measurement).

The case study was carried out through the active participation of researchers and practitioners in the implementation of the public value measurement model (Susman and Evered, 1978). The practitioners involved were from the cultural events and tourism department of the municipality of Ferrara. Interviews with external partners who were involved in the delivery of cultural events were also carried out. The researchers explained the model's functions and purpose to the practitioners, as well as offering continuous support and taking part in all of the meetings relating to its implementation and discussion of the results.

During the first round of meetings in 2014, the model was presented to practitioners to enable the selection and weighting of value drivers. The value drivers are the key elements of the model and were defined by practitioners for each dimension and subdimension. The researchers in this phase provided advice but did not directly intervene in the choice of value drivers and weightings to ensure that they reflected the municipality's priorities. Since the department did not have a full-blown performance measurement system in place, the researchers then proposed and discussed indicators for each of the value drivers.

After this phase, an experimental measurement for 2013 was performed, and another round of meetings with practitioners in 2015 enabled researchers to re-calibrate the indicators in the measurement grid, and to untangle the ways in which such measures affected the work of managers. The researchers also met with event organizers. Public value was measured for 2013 and 2014. The researchers and practitioners discussed the results in a final meeting in May 2016.

## Analysing the case of Ferrara

Figure 3 shows the synthetic measures of public value created in 2013 and 2014. The public value created in 2013 was 3.28, while in 2014 it was 3.01—so the value generated by Ferrara's cultural and tourist activities decreased. For the SV dimension, the public value created was 1.26 in 2013 and to 1.09 in 2014—the benefits provided to users were higher than the sacrifices endured. The EV was 2.15 in 2013 and to 2.13 in 2014—EB overcame ES, with a similar performance in both years. Hence, events

**Figure 2. The measurement grid: an example.**

| MEASUREMENT GRID | | | | | | | | | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | A | B | C | D | E | F | G | *I* | *J* | K | L | | M | *N* | | *O* |
| | DIMENSION | SUB-DIMENSION | S/B | VALUE DRIVERS | INDICATORS | NORMALIZATION SCALE | | *RESULT ACHIEVED* | *NORMALIZED RESULT* | SUB-DIMENSION WEIGHT | *NORMALIZED AND WEIGHTED RESULTS IN SUB-DIMENSIONS* | | DIMENSION WEIGHT | *NORMALIZED AND WEIGHTED RESULTS IN DIMENSIONS* | | *PUBLIC VALUE INDEX* |
| | | | | | | WORST POSSIBLE RESULT | BEST POSSIBLE RESULT | | | | | | | | | |
| | | | | | SACRIFICES (to measure sacrifices decrease) | -10 | 0 | | | | | | | | | |
| | | | | | BENEFITS (to measure benefits increase) | 0 | +10 | | | | *S/B* | *Result* | | *S/B* | *Result* | *Result* |
| EXAMPLES | SOCIAL VALUE | QUANTITAVE | SACRIFICES | Decrease in the event turnout | N° of users at each event / N° of initiatives within each event | 11810 | 378 | *2986,15* | *2,28* | 15% | *0,34* | ***0,10*** | **40%** | - | | - |
| | | | BENEFITS | Increase in daily average initiatives in each event | N° of initiatives within each event / Duration in days of each event | 1 | 46 | *14,07* | *2,90* | | *0,44* | | | | | |

organized by the municipality seem to be financially sustainable and therefore it would make sense to offer the same events in the future. The IV dimension was the only one where value was consumed: -0.13 in 2013 and of -0.22 in 2014—so the municipality was not effectively managing the 'key constituents' of its cultural and tourist activities, such as partnerships with private and not-for-profit concerns or the co-ordination of different kinds of human resources, all of which increase the value created.

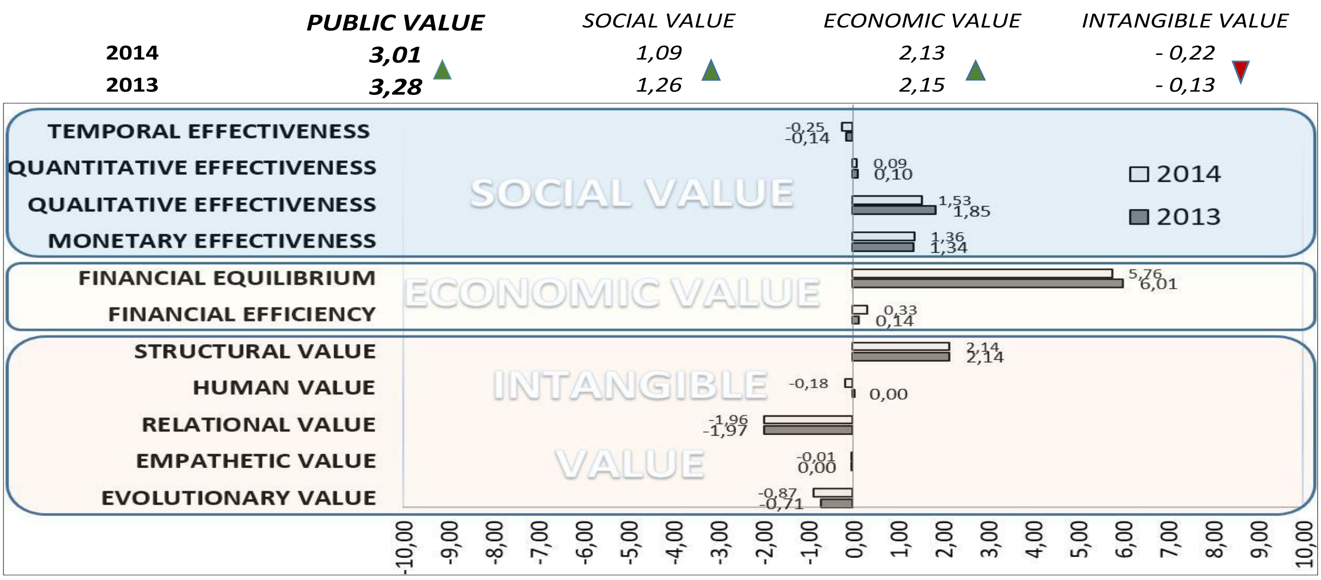
Looking at each subdimension's scores, financial sustainability remains the main strength of the municipality's events. This is a good achievement in a period of financial stress. The ability to provide sustainable events is important to the municipality, and this was evident in the weightings given to this. The subdimension of EV (weighting 40%, figure 3) demonstrated the desire to achieve financial equilibrium. Even with a slight decrease in the period analysed (from 6.01 to 5.76), it is clear that great efforts were made to avoid overspending on events. Variations in per capita expenses and revenues (financial efficiency) did not contribute much to the generation of EV.

As far as the SV dimension was concerned (weighting 35%), Ferrara's cultural and tourist activities were much appreciated by users (qualitative effectiveness), who would welcome more and bigger events. In addition, they wanted them more evenly distributed over the year, and issues like crowding to be dealt with, as evidenced by the substantial equilibrium between benefits and sacrifices in quantitative and temporal effectiveness. The negative variation of SV created between 2013 and 2014 needs to be carefully observed and monitored in the future.

The IV dimension (25% of total public value) was unsatisfactory, showing a difficulty in the intangible assets management. The main strength, captured by structural value, is represented by presence of the requirements for the ISO 20121 certification, which secures accessibility and environmental sustainability of the events. These good results were offset by the other subdimensions, especially by relational value. It is clear how value has been consumed by the poor relationships between organizers and other local actors. In particular, the relationships between the organizers of the events (mainly the municipality and not-for-profit organizations) and the wider commercial environment need to be improved. Building sustainable relationships with local hotels or shops could increase attendance and generate benefits for the local economy. Evolutionary value was also a concern, because ICT was only minimally used to advertise the events and interact with users. Benefits nearly equalled sacrifices for human and empathetic value.

We discussed the results with practitioners who said they found the model useful. Before the model, the municipality had very sparse data about the events, so the cultural events and tourism department did not have a deep understanding of what each event achieved. A more thorough collection of data had begun to meet the requirements for ISO 20121

**Figure 3. Public value created in each dimension and sub-dimension.**



certification, but a full-blown performance measurement system was still lacking. Very specific data was available on turnout and income but the collection of new data, and their 'systematization' through the public value model, provided a deep, holistic view of performance. The slight decrease in value created picked up by the model was not seen by practitioners as particularly significant, but it raised the practitioners' awareness of the need to carefully monitor the events to avoid a deterioration of their performance due to lack of attention. Having a unique measure for the overall value created, and its break down into different inter-connected dimensions, was appreciated by practitioners for highlighting the areas which required attention. Practitioners wanted to improve some of the indicators, for example more detailed customer satisfaction surveys for SV.

The results provided by the model, were, according to practitioners, particularly useful for decision-making and needed to be circulated to all concerned with organizing and financing events to improve co-ordination. Given the very complex nature of the system and the need of technical knowledge to interpret the data, practitioners were doubtful about using the model to communicate results to citizens. However, much emphasis has been placed in the academic literature on using information about public value creation and measurement to promote democracy and active citizenship, triggering a dialogue between citizens and the public administration (Bozeman, 2002). This would require giving an understandable 'public value account' (Moore, 2014) to citizens.

**Discussion and conclusion**

Our new model was able to measure the value created by Ferrara's cultural and tourist activities in both 2013 and 2014. Practitioners recognized the usefulness of the model, as it measured a decrease in value that would have not been noticed otherwise. Practitioners liked that the model improved their decision-making and co-ordination of events. They were skeptical, however, about using the model for accountability purposes. This was because it is hard to define what public value actually is.

The model has some limits. First, there is a risk of subjectivity when choosing value drivers. The same issue affects the weighting of the three dimensions, which could potentially be manipulated in order to give more prominence to the dimensions which present better results. A further risk relates to the normalized decimal scale. In the case study, percentages were used (from 0% to 100% or from 100% to 0%) to minimize the risk of subjectivity in setting the extremes of the scale. However, the use of the model as a tool for decision-making and performance improvement rather than for communicating results achieved to the public, as suggested by practitioners, could reduce the incentive for manipulation.

Despite these limits, this model has many clear advantages. First, it forces an organization to re-think its performance measurement and management system by asking staff to define the key constituents of value generation and how these might be reliably measured. As a result of this exercise, the need to collect new data might emerge. As demonstrated by the case study, it is not always easy to perceive variations in public value generated from one year to the next, and having a reliable measure can help in avoiding deterioration over time. The VP model offers a holistic view of the value of a service, so the organization can focus on critical areas where public value has been consumed. It also helps in highlighting the connections between different dimensions of value, so that politicians and managers understand the impact of their decisions on every dimension and on the total value generated at the same time. A wide application of the model is possible because it is not linked to any context-specific factor. Its conceptual structure always remains the same—only the value drivers, the indicators and the extremes of the normalized scale need to be tailored to different cases. Due to the normalization process, the results captured by the different context-specific indicators are always traced back to a scale ranging from zero to 10, securing homogeneity in the measurement process.

Future research could usefully further test and develop our model. Comparisons between public bodies from different countries would be particularly fruitful as they could provide a deeper understanding of how the model is used and results interpreted in different cultural, legal and organizational contexts. Finally, research is needed to increase our understanding of how to use public value measures to discharge accountability to external stakeholders.

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**IMPACT**

This paper makes an important contribution to the practice of public value management. Although the focus is on how to measure the value created by an Italian local authority, the model the authors present has the potential for wide application. A good public value management system will support public managers and politicians in their decision-making.

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